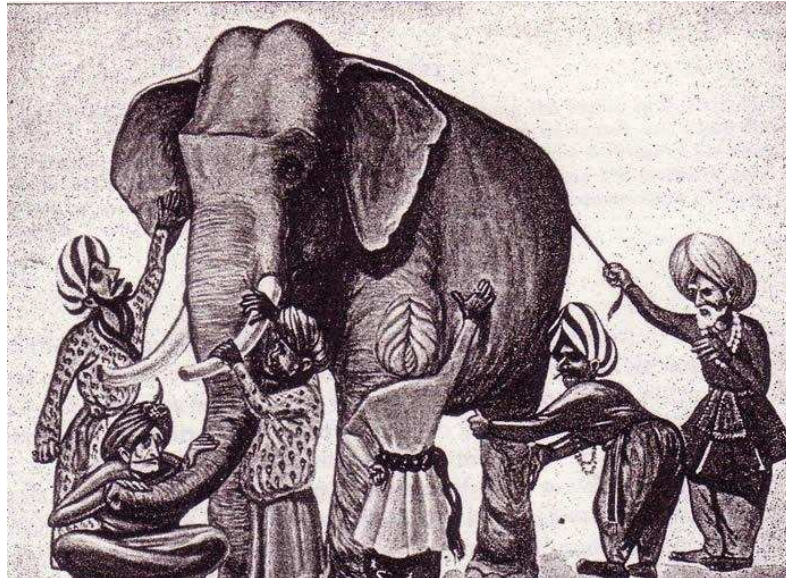




<http://www.thepoachedegg.net/blind%20men%20and%20elephant.jpg>

Communication Perspectives

A synthesis of various communication theories
and what they mean to the public relations
practitioner

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Communication Theory GPRL 6102

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26 April 2013

Introduction

A foray into communication theory could be described as an encounter with the elephant in the popular Indian parable attributed to Jainism¹. Like the challenge encountered by the blind men, the field of communication is so broad and each theorist is perhaps so blinded by their own bias that one could say that all of what constitutes communication can only be reasonably explored one small section at a time. The next logical step would be to have a generalist collate these limited viewpoints and amalgamate them into an appropriate whole.

This essay examines an assortment of subjects relating to communications from the various viewpoints of theorists encountered during the course readings and endeavours to synthesise these into a coherent whole while considering their practical relevance to public relations professionals.

Based on the course material covered, a good place to begin in order to discuss the various communication theory viewpoints is with Robert Craig's perspective that even though a coherent universal theory of communication does not yet exist it should still be strived for (Craig 1999 p. 119). He proposes that the varied literature available on the subject suggests that communication theories are an amalgam of ideas that find their roots in such diverse disciplines as anthropology, literature, mathematics, engineering, sociology, philosophy and psychology.

Rather than addressing a field of theory, we appear to be operating primarily in separate domains. Books and articles on communication theory seldom mention other works on communication theory except within narrow (inter)disciplinary specialties and schools of thought. Except within these little groups, communication theorists apparently neither agree nor disagree about much of anything. There is no canon of general theory to which they all refer. There are no common goals that unite them, no contentious issues that divide them. For the most part, they simply ignore each other (p. 119-120).

This apparent lack of cohesiveness, Craig later argues, and I agree, actually serves as a rich smorgasbord where communication theorists can draw from to build their individual perspectives. He subsequently identifies this approach to communication theory as "a coherent field of metadiscursive practice" (p. 120).

Although communication theory will likely never achieve anything resembling a fully unified discipline, through reasonable constructive and rational discourse, theorists should be able to agree on some common fundamentals (p. 124).

Craig goes on to describe his idea of a coherent “metamodel” of communication theory based on a “metadiscourse” based on seven traditions of communication theory: rhetoric, semiotic, phenomenological, cybernetic, sociopsychological, sociocultural and criticism (p. 133).

These are a good starting point as they highlight the variety of perspectives and the importance of interdisciplinary discourse. As communication professionals, the discourse itself is a worthy ideal. Going back to the parable of the blind men and the elephant which illustrates the challenge of understanding the broad field that communication encompasses, the only way the blind men would ever be able to get a coherent picture of the beast they are trying to visualise would be by engaging in constructive discourse, sharing each other’s perspectives in order to gain a broader and more exact idea of what an elephant is all about.

A few different viewpoints:

For the purpose of this essay, a selection of theorists’ distinct perspectives is summarized and an attempt made to consider their contributions towards a practical synthesis for public relations practitioners. The theorists selected include: Robert Craig, Marshall McLuhan, Harold Innis, Pierre Bourdieu, Bruce Berger, Robert Kenny and James Carey.

Likely the most popular communication paradigm for western culture, the transmission model is an appropriate starting point when discussing communications. James Carey explains the transmission model of communication as the “transmission of signals or messages over distance for the purpose of control” (Carey 2009 p.12). With the advent of modern technology, the means of transmission has become more and more specialized to the point that a reference to the field of communications today is often assumed to be a reference to communication technologyⁱⁱ.

When it comes to communication technology and its impact on communication theory, two important theorists are Marshall McLuan and Harold Innis.

Marshall McLuhan’s emphasis on the impact of communication technology (McLuhan 1997)

In significant contrast to Craig’s search for a coherent multidisciplinary communication theory are other theorists who focused exclusively upon one particular facet of communication such as was the case with Marshal McLuhan’s emphasis on what he considered to be the deterministic influence of media technologies. In his famous interview with Playboy Magazine, McLuhan went so far to insist that the medium is where all of the influence of communication lays. He clarified his “medium is the message” or “massage” maxim by insisting, “The content or message of any particular medium has about as much importance as the stencilling on the casing of an atomic bomb” (p. 237-238).

Later in the same interview though, McLuhan appears to somewhat soften his stance by clarifying his insistence upon the importance of the medium over the message.

By stressing that the medium is the message rather than the content, I'm not suggesting that content plays no role—merely that it plays a distinctly subordinate role... By placing all the stress on content and practically none on the medium, we lose all chance of perceiving and influencing the impact of new technologies on man, and thus we are always dumfounded by—and unprepared for—the revolutionary environmental transformations induced by new media (p. 247).

McLuhan's colourful and unconventional approach was certainly popular and this made him an easy target for contemporary critics of his work. Despite recognizing his special brand of genius, James Carey describes McLuhan's terminology as "ill-defined and inconsistently used and maddeningly obtuse" (Carey 1967 p. 24). However, as revealed in the quote from the Playboy interview above, his agenda could have simply been to exaggerate his claims in order to challenge his audience's attention away from the traditional emphasis placed on content. One could argue that his colourful use of language and hyperbole was a kind of shock treatment used to achieve this aim.

The lesson that public relations practitioners can take from McLuhan, notwithstanding his extreme determinism when it came to the impact of technology on the future of humanity, is that, in addition to content, the very nature of various types of media used in communications influences the audience in particular ways and has in itself a significant impact on society. As such, the particular nature of each medium needs to seriously be taken into consideration when contemplating a communications approach.

Although McLuhan was significantly influenced by Harold Innis' bias of communication theory his focus was on media technology's effect on sensory rather than social organizations (p. 25).

Harold Innis' bias theory (Comer 2001)

Harol Innis is recognized for his assertion that the quality of certain mediums results in a bias of time over space and vice-versa. For example, solid media such as books favour time over space because of their solid and persistent nature whereas the ephemeral and portable nature of mediums such as radio and the telegraph result in a bias of space over time (Carey 1967 p. 9). Time biased media are more persistent, they are useful for storing information but they make information more difficult to transmit over space because they have to be physically transported whereas space biased media can be transmitted over long distances instantly and seemingly with little effort, but its nature is such that it has very little if no staying power.

However, Innis' bias theory was much broader and all encompassing. Although he was criticised by some as a determinist, a closer reading of his work reveals that he applied his concept of bias in a non-determinist way. His bias theory was more of an analytical means using communication media to assist in understanding historical development. By focusing on cultural biases, Innis was concerned with "why we attend to the things which we attend" (Comer 2001 p. 282).

Innis understood that media play important roles in the dissemination of ways of knowing through space and/or time. Efforts to control space and/or time also involve attempts to monopolize force which, according to Innis, involve a range of control activities from brutal oppression to the more subtle implementation of surveillance technologies (p. 283).

Innis bias theory, in contrast to McLuhan's strict determinism, compels the observer to recognize the factors at work, the social and technological biases that impact society throughout history. By recognizing those biases it is possible to subsequently effect necessary changes to maintain a balance. For example, Innis would likely be quite concerned with the 21st century obsession with the current media technologies' focus on the expansion of space and the its corresponding neglect of time (p. 292). However, he might be somewhat comforted by the fact that the Internet today is not only a means to transmit and network information, it also acts as an incredibly large database where information can be stored and shared.

Innis' theory serves as an important analytical tool for public relations practitioners. It can assist communicators understand the potential challenges facing society and propose solutions to restore the necessary balance between extremes.

The transmission of information Shifting from technology to sociology and the impact of social capital on communications.

Pierre Bourdieu and social capital (Ihlen 2005)

Although Pierre Bourdieu was known as a prominent sociologist, Oyvind Ihlen highlighted the relevance of his concept of social capital to the field of communication as it relates to public relations.

Social capital is defined by Bourdieu "as the aggregate of the actual or potential resources which are linked to possession of a durable network of more or less institutionalized relationships of mutual acquaintance and recognition..." (p. 494). In other words, it can be defined as the worth of an institution's popularity or approval rating by its publics. Seeing that the field of public relations is concerned with successfully managing the relationship between an organization and

its publics, it is in the best interest of public relations professionals to seek to maintain or increase their institutions' social capital.

Effective communications within the context of increasing social capital is focused on efficient network and relationship building. It is a challenging principle to quantify but it contributes to the success of an organization by reducing costs, improve productivity and contribute to overall efficiency.

Depending on the nature of the institution in question, means of investment in social capital include outreach activities that strengthen an organisation's relationship with various potential stakeholders such as activist groups, journalists and researchers (p. 495).

An example of the impact of social capital on organizations from a military public affairs perspective is the significant cuts to the Canadian military in the years following the 1993 scandal in Somalia (Bercuson 2009). Canadians were shocked with the perceived lack of professionalism of their troops revealed through media reports of this incident.

The lack of professionalism was reflected in the way the media was treated throughout the affair.

By closing ranks in defence of the regiment, by scolding journalists for their failure to understand military realities, and by offering a succession of thin rationalizations both for the crimes committed and the attitudes unmasked, the military placed itself well on the road to losing perhaps the most important public relations battle in its history.
(Oliver 1999 p.125)

The displeasure of the Canadian public was acutely demonstrated in the following years' as their government severely curtailed available funding for military equipment and personnel. What happened in Somalia was inexcusable, but some, like retired General Rick Hillier, observed that the resultant negative impact on the Canadian public's perception of their military and was somewhat out of sync with reality.

Hillier recorded how Canadian Press reporter, John Ward, was astonished at the way Canadians viewed their military following the Somalia incident. Following a seven-year assignment overseas, Ward related that the Canadian military at that time was actually very highly regarded by the international community at that time. "Their credibility was huge, people valued them, wanted them. Canadian soldiers were like gods... I came back here to find they're lower than dirt? Quite incredible" (Hillier 2009 p. 127).

So, one thousand people went, worked their asses off under appalling conditions in an ambiguous, unclear mission, without much support from the government of Canada, and

all that people remember is that one episode. Even though what happened was a major failing and led to some badly needed, the perception of the mission was that it was an absolute disaster (p.127).

Popularly recognized as the “decade of darkness” for Canada’s military, this period was eventually followed by a painstaking gradual increase in funds and material as the Canadian public’s confidence and pride in their military slowly increased following the positive media stories and images of soldiers, sailors and air force personnel assisting civil authorities and provided much needed relief during the 1997 Manitoba flood.

The Winnipeg flood changed the way many individual journalists and some news organizations viewed the Canadian Forces. They saw that they were not an organization of ogres, blood-thirsty demons and ill disciplined thugs... and that’s what they communicated to Canadians (p. 180).

Later, in 1998, the Canadian Forces response to the destructive ice storm that impacted large parts of Quebec and Ontario continued the trend of Canadian public gratitude towards their military.

The reaction of the people across eastern Ontario and in Ottawa was phenomenal, so positive and from a broad spectrum of the populace. It became another step in the rejuvenation of the Canadian Forces (pp. 202-203).

The above example demonstrates how an institution’s public image can have a significant impact on what economists call the “bottom line.” Although its impact may be difficult to measure, especially in the short term, it is in organizations’ best interest to invest in social capital by reaching out to and networking with its various publics.

The communications approach of Canada’s military following the Somalia incident, “scolding journalists for their failure to understand military realities, and by offering a succession of thin rationalizations both for the crimes committed and the attitudes unmasked” (Oliver 1999 p.125), and the timely and transparent communications approach adopted in 2010 when it was discovered that one of their senior leaders (Russell Williams) was a serial killer, stand in sharp contrast to each other. One could argue that, of the two, the Williams affair was likely the most heinous crime, yet the impact on the Canadian public’s perception of their military was completely different. What changed?

This is my personal opinion but I would suggest that it had partly to do with power dynamics at senior levels as it relates to the influence public affairs officers had in each case. I suggest this because the Canadian Forces basic policy of informing the public “in a manner that is accurate,

complete, objective, timely, relevant, understandable, and open and transparent within the law”ⁱⁱⁱ, which was successfully followed after Russell William’s arrest, has not changed fundamentally over that time period. The public relations failure after the Somalia affair could therefore be partly because public relations practitioners, whose mission is to advise command on communications decisions, failed to get their message across to them.

Much of the negative public perception following the Somalia affair could have therefore been mitigated by better communication practices, but the influence of the expertise public relations professionals bring to an organization is limited by the power dynamics of that organization.

Bruce Berger and the dynamics of power influencing decisions in organizations (Berger 2005)

Berger focuses on the relationship between public relations practitioners and the key decision makers within organizations, identified as the “dominant coalition” by organizational theorists. He argues that public relations personnel are often left out of this inner circle and that even when they succeed in becoming members of it, the complex dynamics of power relations, processes and practices intrinsic to dominant coalitions within organizations do not necessarily result in their “doing the right thing” (p. 5).

He identifies three types of power dynamics: “power over,” “power with” and “power to.” The first is identified as a traditional dominance model that is manifested through decision making borne out of control, instrumentalism and self-interest that communications professionals seek to exert influence upon. The second is an empowerment model where decisions come about through collaboration (Berger later proposes that this is likely to be equated as a “feminine ideology” (p. 22)) and the third is manifested through forms of resistance in an effort to counter dominance (p. 6).

Although it appears self-evident that the best hope for public relations professionals lies in becoming part of the dominant coalition so as to exert influence with the key decision-makers, Berger’s research reveals that being part of the inner circle may actually result in a loss of objectivity identified as “golden handcuffs” that limits their ability to serve the best interest of the organization (p. 14). Practitioners, who make it into the dominant coalition, can be tempted by the economic and social benefits of belonging to the inner-circle, to play along and simply comply with the inner-circle’s wishes, rather than carry out their roles as specialized and objective communications advisors.

Berger subsequently identifies two existing roles for public relations professionals, that of technician and manager, and proposes a third one, that of an activist. Based on his research and observations he suggests that technicians are unlikely to ever find themselves within the dominant coalition while managers, who are much more likely to gain admission, but that they

may be tempted by the “golden handcuffs” and lose their edge as advisors. The role of activist, on the other hand, as a “power to” broker is seen as a means to assist organizations develop a social conscience by engaging with relevant coalitions in appropriate public environments that relate to the organization’s ideals (p. 25).

If one is to accept this role for public relations professionals to be activists who assist organizations develop a social conscience, one is then compelled to confront the domain of ethics and ideals.

Robert Kenny’s argument for living as answerable agents (Kenny 2007)

Kenny suggests that ethical behaviour does not necessarily have to relate to the moral fabric of an agent. By adopting the role of answerable agents who must take into consideration the expectations of others, individuals or organizations are fulfilling a cause and effect dynamic rather than ethical standards in order to succeed. Kenny bases this on the following observation:

Society and its agents, in various ways and at various levels, regularly demand an answerable performance, rather than one grounded in virtue or some other ethically determined rationale. Indeed, there are occasions when our capacity to treat a moral crisis exclusively in terms of the answerabilities that attend it, using no part of our ethical judgment, is a necessary condition for being treated as a person of integrity, and for maintaining our freedom (p. 269).

This teleological or what some term utilitarian ethos based on consequences is a useful one for communications advisors because it could be argued that, while it may be quite challenging to argue for a desirable action based on a deontological model which focuses on the moral quality of the act itself regardless of outcome, it is much more practical to simply point out potential outcomes to a decision-maker and argue for the action that will most likely result in the most desirable outcome.

In a democracy, where it is understood that the will and expectations of the people rule, it is only reasonable to expect organizations serving the people to adopt policies and carry out activities that meet the expectations of the various publics they serve. Using the example of the public relations disaster resulting from the Somalia affair; if the decision-makers had simply met the expectations of their publics, rather than be perceived as self-servingly obfuscating the communication process, the results would have likely been markedly different. The “social conscience” Berger refers to when discussing the role of activism for public relations (Berger 2005 p. 25) could therefore be translated as the deliberate inclination of individuals or organizations to meet the reasonable expectations of society.

James Carey and the concept of communication as culture (Carey 2009)

Carey asserted that the transmission model of communication is a paradigm that dominates our culture, that it is likely a product of all industrial cultures.

“It is defined by terms such as “imparting,” “sending,” “transmitting,” or “giving information to others.” It is formed from a metaphor of geography or transportation. In the nineteenth century but to a lesser extent today, the movement of goods or people and the movement of information were seen as essentially identical processes and both were described by the common noun “communication.” The center of this idea of communication is the transmission of signals or messages over distance for the purpose of control. It is a view of communication that derives from one of the most ancient of human dreams: the desire to increase the speed and effect of messages as they travel in space (p. 12).

Based on the above definition the transmission model appears symmetrical to a trade or delivery focused culture. The flow of goods or information is unidirectional and intended to control. The technological aspect is reflected by the use of transmitters rather than transceivers.

In consideration of the transmission model of communications, the topics covered so far include the transmitters (the nature and impact of communication technology as means of transmissions), the receivers (human society at large in the form of the various publics the transmissions are directed towards in order to foster and gain influence or social capital) the messengers (as defined by the decision making power dynamics of organizations) and the ethics or motivation that shape the communication process.

Carey proposed an alternate paradigm, the ritual view of communication. Although not nearly as prominent in western thinking, compared to the transmission model, the ritual view is the grandfather of the two. According to this paradigm, communication is linked to its common roots with words such as community, commonness and communion. These related words imply a sense of togetherness, participation, association; fellowship and sharing that are not evident in the transmission model. The ritual view *“sees the original or highest manifestation of communication not in the transmission of intelligent information but in the construction and maintenance of an ordered, meaningful cultural world that can serve as a control and container for human action.”* Compared to the transmission view’s unidirectional flow of information for the purpose of control, the flow of information in the ritual view is an uncontrolled, pan-directional flow of community ideals transmitted through various artistic forms such as architecture, plays, dance and stories that represent a manifestation an “ongoing fragile social process” (p. 15).

By exploring the ritualistic view of communication, Carey was attempting to invigorate the discussion about communication theory. He felt that the transmission view was exhausted. Through the ritual view he found a fresh perspective based on ancient concepts where communication is revealed “as a symbolic process where reality is produced, maintained, repaired and transformed” (p.19).

The transmission view of communication and its related models of power, efficiency and control impart a perspective of society that sees itself in relation to power, property, production, and trade while the ritual view sees human experience is much broader. Yet society is more than the mere relationship of power and trade, it includes the experience of the arts, the world of ideas and values, a spiritual dimension and intellectual pursuit. Carey proposed that focusing our efforts in further developing and encouraging the ritual view is a means to restore balance.

The object, then, of recasting our studies of communication in terms of a ritual model is not only to more firmly grasp the essence of this “wonderful” process but to give us a way in which to rebuild a model of and for communication of some restorative value in reshaping our common culture (p. 27).

New media, Carey, Innis and McLuhan

It would be interesting to hear what James Carey would have to say about the impact of the explosion of new media technologies, especially over the last decade. In fact, I would love to be a fly on the wall in a room with Carey, Innis and McLuhan if they were to suddenly appear see the new developments in media technologies since their death.

I suspect that McLuhan would be surprised that his prophecies regarding the natural progression of media technology to pure “electric media” did not yet result a centralized globally controlled civilization of automatons (McLuhan 1997). As Carey pointed out, McLuhan severely overestimated “the inflexibility of media of communication. While any given medium confronts an artist with certain inherent constraints, media still allow wide latitude for innovation and artistic manipulation” (Carey 1967 p. 28).

According to Edward Comor, “Innis was concerned with the annihilation of civilization coming when space or time becomes a cultural obsession” (Comor 2001 p. 290). Now that technology, with the increased popularity of hand held micro-computers/transceivers we call smartphones and the popularity and impact of social networks, has rendered the magic of decentralized instant communication possible on a global scale, Innis could be expected to count the days to Armageddon. However, with the corresponding advent of the incredibly large and easily available and accessible online electronic media storage capabilities, one could argue that there is a corresponding time bias factor to new media technologies that could also reassure Innis.

Carey, on the other hand, would likely be thrilled with the new potential that resides in new media for “communion,” “sharing,” and “communities” inherent, especially in social media,

where the power dynamics are so fundamentally different from the traditional transmission model. It is certainly a medium that encourages equal access to the world of ideas and related discussions.

Conclusion

One of the greatest difficulty in defining communication is that it is such an all-encompassing and mostly taken-for-granted part of human existence and experience. Communication in relation to humanity is like water to the fish, they are likely unaware of the very medium their life depends on.

I began this essay with the proposal that, like the blind men in the Indian parable of the elephant, communication theorists are challenged by limited perspective when it comes to identifying a coherent, all encompassing theory of communication. A comprehensive theory would have to include a plethora of considerations and various fields of discipline. Robert Craig suggested seven: rhetoric, semiology, phenomenology, cybernetics, socio-psychology, socio-culturalism and criticism (Craig 1999 p. 133).

Craig is one theorist who advocated for a meeting of the minds and an effort to create a coherent theory of communication. Rather than operating independently in separate domains, he calls for theorists to come together under one field.

The main implication for our disciplinary practice is that we communication theorists all now have something very important to argue about—the social practice of communication—so we should stop ignoring each other and start addressing our work to the field of communication theory. As a result of our doing so, there will be a field of communication theory. What exactly is involved in addressing our work to the field? Three things, I suggest (along with Anderson, 1996): (a) orienting to the field as a broad disciplinary audience; (b) giving voice to the field’s distinctive concerns in interdisciplinary research; and (c) educating our students in the field (Craig 1999 pp. 152-153).

As Innis and McLuhan demonstrated, the communication medium is a critical part of communication theory. It impacts the expectations of society and, while I would not go so far as agreeing with McLuhan famous maxim, I guess it’s a matter of interpreting what is “the message,” it is amply evident that the medium used in communication dramatically influences society. I would not agree that it embodies the message but that it shapes and influences the message in fundamental ways that require the attention of communication theorists and practitioners.

Communication doesn't happen in a vacuum though; it always involves some kind of public. While the medium is its means, the public can be said to be related to its end or purpose. While my primary job as a public affairs officer is to inform, I believe in effect based communications. Transmitting information without regard to the publics we serve is doomed to be ineffective and counter-productive. I concur with Kenny, we should act as answerable agents (Kenny 2007), a teleological approach is key to insuring that we don't only meet the needs of our organizations, but also the expectations of our publics in order to foster social capital.

As I shared with a public affairs colleague following a discussion years ago when he expressed his reservations in using social media to interact with Canadians about our mission; in the end, it doesn't really matter what we, as communication professionals, think of media technology like Facebook, the fact that a large majority of our publics use it is what matters. As we struggle to keep up with emerging technologies, we need to keep that fact in mind. The value of using social media to reach out to Canadians during a mission was proven when Hurricane Igor struck Newfoundland in the fall of 2010. The Canadian military sent over a thousand soldiers, sailors and air force personnel to assist in clean up and rebuilding efforts. The temporary Facebook page that was immediately set up as a means to communicate the mission directly and instantly to our public not only served to inform but provided valuable feedback directly from Newfoundlanders who were affected by the destruction.

I agree with Carey that the transmission model of communication, though essential, is not enough. There is a need to go well beyond the simple transmission of information. There needs to be a better focus on culture beyond the simplistic, materialist western model. We need to be promoting a conversation, sharing ideas, fostering a communion of society.

In terms of final thoughts, no one, I believe, has ever said it better than James Carey is recorded as saying during final remarks following an interview at the Poynter Institute in St. Petersburg, Florida in the spring of 1991:

There are no final thoughts. I quote all the time these wonderful lines of Kenneth Burke... Life is a conversation. When we enter, it is already going on. We try to catch the drift of it. We exit before it's over. The first lesson any pragmatist learns is that at the hour of our death, we are rewriting our biography for the last time. And then the first hour into our death, someone else rewrites the biography for us. Our children, our spouses, our friends. Do you remember what he was like... what he said... what he did... And so in that sense, life is a conversation that continuously goes on, that continuously renews itself, and, therefore, renews you. All work is a matter of self-renewal, which is a renewal of the other. No one has the last word. There are no final thoughts, there is no end to the conversation (Carey 2009).

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End Notes:

ⁱ Based out of India, Jainism is described as one of the oldest religions, for a narrative of its version of the parable of the blind men and the elephant, see:
<http://www.jainworld.com/education/stories25.asp>

ⁱⁱ For example, a search for “field of communication” conducted with Google images today results primarily in images of communication devices, especially cell phones.

ⁱⁱⁱ See first policy statement in the Defence Administrative Orders and Directives Public Affairs Policy at <http://www.admfincs.forces.gc.ca/dao-doa/2000/2008-0-eng.asp>.